

Tony Hawk's Pro Skater 3

Pro-foundly entertaining

So you've checked out those *Extreme Sports* dudes and dudettes wheel over cars, grind over pipes in their entire body-twisting, knee-bending glory. Exciting stuff for sure. *Tony Hawk's Pro Skater 3* (THPS3) takes us one step away from the spectator seat that the television puts us in and delivers an as-good-as-it-gets experience on our computer monitors.

Although this game is available for all the major consoles, what separates the PC version from the rest is the inclusion of some great network play. The online component successfully utilises the skating aspect to put an enjoyable spin on the eight different modes of play. Thus Graffiti calls for you to tag an obstacle or an area by pulling off a trick, Trick Attack pits you against your opposition in a test of skill, Slap! awards points for literally running into other players, Control the Zone is a contest of dominat-



ing an area, and so on. Although play over the Internet is not as solid as it should have been, sessions over a LAN are highly recommended. The single-player element is an outstanding achievement. Included here is the Free Skate mode which offers unlimited skating without

score-tracking—an ideal way to get intimate with a level. But the crux of the game lies in the Career mode where you will earn points and reputation as you unlock new levels, skaters, and tricks.

For a PC title, the graphic splendour is a bit of a hit-and-miss show. The models are greatly detailed and very natural looking, while the animations are convincing and immersive. But what tears away from the visual quality are the textures used—most of them are too uniform and lack detail, imparting a very uninspiring look to an otherwise splendid game. However, where the textures miss, the audio facet makes up with excellent sound effects and a lively soundtrack. The only caveat is that THPS3 would be better approached with a gamepad—if any game deserves to be pampered with that peripheral device, it is this one!

Minimum System Requirements: 300 MHz processor, 64 MB RAM, 8 MB DirectX 8 compatible 3D card ■ **Genre:** Sports

Developer: Neversoft ■ **Distributor:** Milestone Interactive ■ **Phone:** 022-8381614 ■ **Web site:** www.activisiono2.com/tony_hawk/ ■ **Price:** Rs 699

Rating: ★★★★★



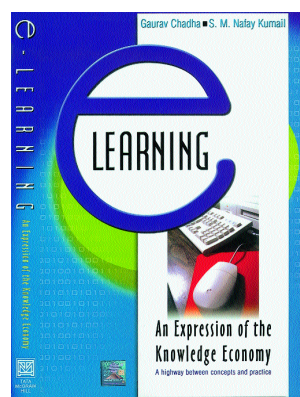
E-LEARNING, AN EXPRESSION OF THE KNOWLEDGE ECONOMY

Economically unknowledgeable

Let us begin by saying: Look for another book, this one holds no value for a professional and is not aimed at the novice. The stated objective of this book is 'the imminent need for sharing the novel ways of learning we (the authors) have created and experienced'. However, it is bereft of any practical experience or novel insights. The book attempts to cover a broad spectrum of the e-learning domains such as the history and development of teaching techniques, analysis of learning models, job roles in e-learning, as well as the technology used to develop e-learning solutions. However, it manages to touch on each topic only fleetingly, and provides

overviews that may interest the novices but leave the professional, whom the book is primarily targeted at, uninformed. Important technologies like XML are dismissed within a few meagre lines and the usage scenarios completely miss the point.

The authors are project managers, yet they repeatedly attempt to make a business case for



e-learning. The result is a book that is predictably simple-minded, dripping with enthusiasm and entirely lacking in any kind of balanced thought and content. The authors of the book generously state upfront that much of the contained material is repetitive—a candid preview into what's in store for the discerning reader.

The facts and concepts contained within its pages can easily fit into a small booklet and are certainly not worth the time and expense the book demands.

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